Young Candidates Say Fixing Housing Starts With Living It

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Across the United States, homes and apartments have become so expensive that many young adults are still renting with roommates in their thirties. A **shortage** of housing has pushed prices up, and saving for a first home can feel nearly impossible. Now some of the youngest people running for office say living this problem gives them the energy to fix it.

In Connecticut, 28-year-old Democrat Olaleye Onikuyide is running for state representative. He lives with his parents to save money and rides public transit. Years ago, he started studying how to make housing cheaper, back when few people were talking about it. "We're in the thick of it," he said, pointing to high housing and gas prices, student loan debt and a tough job market. He wants more mixed-income housing and walkable cities, and says the real action happens at the state level.

Nearby in New Haven, 26-year-old Democrat Eli Sabin is also running for state representative. As a college sophomore, he served on the city council, which changed **zoning** rules to allow denser, more affordable building. Sabin rents his home, like about 70% of his city's residents, and he says that experience matters because most elected officials are homeowners. He wants stronger protections against **eviction** and an easier path to buying a first home.

In Montana, Republican Lukas Schubert is only 21 and campaigning for reelection as a state representative. Housing tops his issues list too. He wants more small **starter homes** instead of only apartments and mansions, and he proposed a tax break for builders who sell new **starter homes** below the local **median** price. It did not pass, but he plans to try again.

Different parties, same message: these young candidates believe their generation can help make housing affordable for everyone.

Word Treasure

shortage -- Not having enough of something that people need.

zoning -- Rules that decide what kinds of buildings can be built in each area.

eviction -- Being forced to leave a home you rent.

median -- The middle value in a set of numbers, with half above and half below.

starter homes -- Smaller, cheaper homes meant for people buying a home for the first time.

Background you need

A state representative is a lawmaker who helps make laws for one state, including rules about building and housing.

Zoning rules decide what can be built in each area, and changing them can allow more homes to be built closer together.

Housing has become expensive in many places because there are not enough homes for everyone who needs one.

When homes are scarce, rents and prices rise, and young adults may live with parents or roommates longer to save money.

Break it down

LEAD: Homes are so expensive that some of the youngest candidates for office, who live the problem themselves, are running on plans to fix it

KEY EVENT: Young candidates in Connecticut and Montana put housing at the top of their campaigns

+- WHO: Olaleye Onikuyide, 28, and Eli Sabin, 26, in Connecticut; Lukas Schubert, 21, in Montana

+- WHERE: Connecticut, including New Haven, and Montana

+- WHY: A housing shortage has pushed prices up, and renters and young adults feel it most

EVIDENCE: Onikuyide lives with his parents to save money; Sabin rents like about 70% of his city and helped change zoning rules; Schubert proposed a tax break for builders of starter homes

OPEN QUESTION: Whether ideas like these can pass and actually make homes cheaper is still unknown

Why it matters

Where people can afford to live shapes jobs, schools and family life, so whether a new generation of lawmakers can ease housing costs affects whole communities, not just first-time buyers.

Test what you remember

1. What problem do the young candidates in the story most want to fix?

(A) Gas stations are closing
(B) Housing has become too expensive for many people
(C) Airplane tickets cost too much
(D) There are not enough schools

2. Where does Olaleye Onikuyide live to save money?

(A) In a mansion
(B) With his parents
(C) On a college campus
(D) Alone in his own apartment

3. What did New Haven's city council change while Eli Sabin served on it?

(A) Zoning rules, to allow denser, more affordable building
(B) Bus fares across the city
(C) School lunch prices
(D) Rules for public parks

4. About what share of people in Sabin's city rent their homes, like he does?

(A) About 10%
(B) About 70%
(C) Almost everyone
(D) About half

5. How old is Montana lawmaker Lukas Schubert?

(A) 26
(B) 21
(C) 35
(D) 28

6. What did Schubert propose to help buyers of first homes?

(A) A ban on mansions
(B) A tax break for builders who sell new starter homes below the local median price
(C) Lower gas prices
(D) Free apartments for students

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: A 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Olaleye Onikuyide: Says young candidates are 'in the thick of it' and wants more mixed-income housing and walkable cities, with the real action at the state level.

2. Eli Sabin: Rents his home and says that experience matters; wants stronger protections against eviction and an easier path to buying a first home.

3. Lukas Schubert: Wants more small starter homes instead of only apartments and mansions, and proposed a tax break for builders who sell them below the local median price; plans to try again after it did not pass.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):